



ENGL 1405 World Literature Unit 7

An Overview of Fantasy Literature, Science Fiction and Magical Realism

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Fantasy Literature

All literature that is fiction is fantastic, if one were to use the etymological meaning of the word, where “fantastic” means “having the quality of the imaginary”. Indeed, all fiction is imaginary, so in that sense, they are all works of fantasy. However, when the term “fantasy literature” is applied as a category or a genre, it does not include the etymological meaning, so it does not encompass all works of fiction. Fantasy literature has come to refer to a canon of literature where the content deals with settings which are not real; plots which are not possible in reality; involving creatures that do not exist in reality.

Many works of fantasy literature are classed as “**Children’s literature**” as it is held that such works are not for mature readers, but that view is fast-changing, with universities offering such works in their literature courses. However, it must be kept in mind that while much of fantasy literature falls under children’s literature, not all children’s literature are fantasy tales. Enid Blyton’s *Famous Five* series is a good example of a case in point. The series falls under children’s literature, but they are not fantasy literature. They fall under the genre of mystery/detective literature. On the other hand, the *Harry Potter* series by J.K. Rowling is classed under children’s literature, while they also belong to fantasy literature.

Fantasy literature has its origins in the **myths and legends** of each culture, but mythical and legendary stories are classed into their own genres. *Oedipus Rex*, an Ancient Greek tragedy, is built upon the legendary character Oedipus; stories of Arthur in England are based on the legends of King Arthur and the myths associated with him. They are not fantasy literature, as the people hold the figures in esteem, and so the figures pass from being mythical to being legendary. In Egypt and Greece, we also have tales of the mythical bird Phoenix and the creature Sphinx. Such tales are myths, as the creatures are not found in reality, but they are so far shrouded in ancient times that they have become part of the historic culture of the lands and are not considered fantasy literature. In some cultures, certain myths can also become religious in the same manner. Levi-Strauss, a famous structural linguist, also laid out the structure of myths based on similarities found across cultures (Levi-Strauss, 1955).



Place this in contrast to the appearance of the Phoenix and the Sphinx in the *Harry Potter* series. That becomes fantasy, as the stories present a realm of magic in modern times, and the magical creatures are presented as magical creatures.

Fantasy literature has its proper birth in what we know to be **fairy tales**. Noted linguist and writer Tolkien wrote on the importance of fairy stories (Tolkien, n.d.). Before him, Vladimir Propp (1928/1968) discussed 31 common elements that he observed in Russian folktales. His work has become famous, as the same traits are observed in fantasy literature in other cultures and times, too. Given below are the chief and common elements, or functions:

- The hero leaves home: The hero's first step in accomplishing his mission;
- The hero is tested: The hero is presented with a choice or questions to prepare him for receiving a magical agent or helper;
- The hero acquires a magical agent: The hero can receive the agent directly, find it, purchase it, or have it prepared for him;
- The hero is pursued: The hero is pursued by someone who tries to kill, eat, or undermine him;
- The hero is rescued: The hero is saved from the pursuit by obstacles, hiding, or being hidden;
- The hero is recognized: The hero is recognized by a mark, brand, or thing given to him;
- The villain is punished: The villain is defeated in combat, banished, or killed while asleep;
- The hero marries and ascends the throne: The hero is rewarded or promoted.

Popular Works of Fantasy Literature

1. Middle Eastern Fantasy

- "The Thousand and One Nights" (Arabian Nights) (8th-14th centuries – compiled)– Anonymous

2. European Fantasy

- "The Lord of the Rings" (1954-1955) by J.R.R. Tolkien
- "The Chronicles of Narnia" (1950-1956) by C.S. Lewis
- "The Hobbit" (1937) by J.R.R. Tolkien
- "Harry Potter" series (1997-2007) by J.K. Rowling
- "The Once and Future King" (1958) by T.H. White
- "The Neverending Story" (1979) by Michael Ende

3. American Fantasy

- "A Song of Ice and Fire" (1996-present) by George R.R. Martin
- "The Wizard of Oz" (1900) by L. Frank Baum



- "The Earthsea Cycle" (1968-2001) by Ursula K. Le Guin
- "The Wheel of Time" (1990-2013) by Robert Jordan

4. Asian Fantasy

- "Journey to the West" (1592) by Wu Cheng'en
- "The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter" (c. 10th century) – Anonymous
- "The Twelve Kingdoms" (1992-present) by Fuyumi Ono

5. African Fantasy

- "Children of Blood and Bone" (2018) by Tomi Adeyemi
- "Zoo City" (2010) by Lauren Beukes

6. Indian Fantasy

- "The Palace of Illusions" (2008) by Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni
Publication: 2008
- "The Shiva Trilogy" (2010-2013) by Amish Tripathi

7. Latin American Fantasy

- "Labyrinths" (1962) by Jorge Luis Borges
- "The Inheritance of Orquídea Divina" (2021) by Zoraida Córdova

8. Nordic Fantasy

- "The Prose Edda" (c. 1220) by Snorri Sturluson

9. Russian Fantasy

- "The Master and Margarita" (1967) by Mikhail Bulgakov

10. Australian Fantasy

- "The Obernewtyn Chronicles" (1987-2015) by Isobelle Carmody

Science Fiction

Science Fiction (Sci fi) in literature refers to a work where science is used in theme and context and in the overall plot. It becomes fiction as it is a work of imagination, not a scientific account. Often, science fiction delves into the world of futuristic inventions. Jules Verne wrote *From the Earth to the Moon* (1865) when the rocket was not invented; *20,000 Leagues Under the Sea* (1869-1870) when the submarine was not invented; *Around the World in 80 Days* (1872) when air-travel did not exist. The works belong to sci fi and not fantasy because the depiction is done rationally using scientific thought and mindset.

Sci fi also features speculative science and technology, envisioning innovations such as robotics, genetic engineering, and cybernetics, and often portrays societies that are either dystopian or utopian, providing a platform to critique real-world social, political, and ethical issues. Sci-fi also delves into questions of human nature, identity, and consciousness through interactions with advanced beings like robots, aliens, or cyborgs, challenging what it means to be human.



Magical Realism

Also known as **magic realism**, this form of fiction rose in the modern age. It depicted elements of fantasy in a real-world setting. Unlike traditional fantasy, where the magical is clearly separate from reality, magical realism blends the two seamlessly, making the extraordinary appear ordinary within the story's universe. This genre is often associated with Latin American literature, but it has been embraced worldwide.

Key elements of magical realism include:

- **Ordinary settings:** Stories take place in familiar, real-world environments.
- **Supernatural elements:** Magic or fantastical occurrences are presented as part of everyday life.
- **Nonchalant tone:** Characters often accept the magical as part of reality without surprise or disbelief.
- **Commentary on social/political issues:** Many works of magical realism reflect the complexities of culture, history, or politics, especially in postcolonial contexts.

Notable Works of Magical Realism:

- "One Hundred Years of Solitude" by Gabriel García Márquez (1967)
- "The House of the Spirits" by Isabel Allende (1982)
- "Midnight's Children" by Salman Rushdie (1981)
- "Beloved" by Toni Morrison (1987)

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